Before Shah Shuja's arrival, Ludhiana was known mainly as a centre of the flesh trade, through which girls from the Punjab Hill States and Kashmir – considered the fairest and most beautiful in the region – passed into slavery in the Sikh-controlled Punjab and Hindustan.[16] Shah Shuja's arrival with his court-in-exile began its transformation from a centre of slave dealing into a major hub of political intrigue and espionage. Over the decades to come it was to transform into the principal British listening post for the Punjab, the Himalayas and Central Asia: a place full of chancers and hoaxers, deserters, mercenaries and spies, the meeting place of the plotters and malcontents of Afghanistan, Ranjit Singh's dominions, the disputed valley of Kashmir and the dominions of the Company.[17]

The Boston-born, hookah-smoking, pyjama-wearing Sir David Ochterlony was the first British Agent in Ludhiana. From there he had established the Company's exact frontiers with Ranjit Singh. These were guarded by a regiment of Irregular Horse belonging to Ochterlony's friend James Skinner, the dashing Rajput-Scottish warlord. From their twin bases in Hansi and Ludhiana, Skinner's 'Yellow Boys' became the Company's first North West Frontier Force, and the first line of defence against whatever might come down the Khyber or over the Sutlej.[18] With their scarlet turbans, silver-edged girdles, black shields and bright yellow tunics, Skinner's men were, according to one contemporary observer, 'the most showy and picturesque cavaliers I have ever seen'.

When Wa'fa Begum first sent her eunuchs ahead to request asylum from the British in 1812 there had been a disagreement between Ochterlony and his colleagues about taking in the family of the fallen Shah. The Delhi Resident Charles Metcalfe, who had negotiated the Company's original treaty with Ranjit Singh at the time of Napoleon's planned invasion of India, argued strongly against the move, saying it would strain relations with an important ally with little benefit to the Company. It was, he wrote, 'an event so pregnant with inconvenience, embarrassment and probable expense, as to render it extremely desirous that it should not take place, and should be discouraged by every means consistent with the observance of respect due to her rank and misfortunes'.[19]

Ochterlony was having none of it. He knew from personal experience what it was like to be a defeated refugee: his father was a Highland Scot who had settled in Massachusetts and fought as a Loyalist during the American Revolution. When Washington's Patriots saw off the British, the